

Understanding Purpose in Life (UPL)

Methodology: Interactive teaching, African proverbs, folktales, personal testimonies, peer exercises, and journaling.

Discovering the Foundations of Purpose

Session 1 – Introduction to Life’s Purpose (1 hour)

Objective: Understand the concept of purpose and why it matters.

The Story of the Three Builders: The story of the three bricklayers is based on the rebuilding of St. Paul’s Cathedral after a fire burned through London in 1666.

An architect was visiting the project site and loved to interact with those doing the work and approached three bricklayers. He asked them each individually, “what are you doing?”.

The first bricklayer replied, *“I’m a bricklayer. I’m working hard to lay bricks to earn money so I can feed my family.”* The man seemed tired and wasn’t as far along with his work as the others.

The second bricklayer says, *“I’m a builder. I’m building the finest, strongest wall. This wall will be a foundation for this building and will protect everyone who is inside.”*

The third bricklayer replied with energy and a light in his eye, *“I’m a cathedral builder. I’m building a great cathedral, where people can gather, pray and celebrate the Almighty.”*

This is a demonstration that everything we experience is based on our understanding of purpose and depth of vision. Everything is “an inside job.” How we interpret what we do, or experience, is based on the purpose of the action and the actor, for the actor’s mindset reflects on purpose.

- **Key Topics:**
 - **What is life's purpose? 7 Questions for Clarity:**

1. What makes you feel most alive?
2. What problem in the world gets you most emotionally charged?
3. What are you naturally good at?
4. What is your life's most meaningful event or experience?
5. What would you do if you had zero fear?
6. Who is your idol, living or dead, and why?
7. What do you want to be your enduring legacy?

Answer the foregoing questions sincerely, for therein lies the discovery of your purpose.

- **Difference between goals, vision, and purpose.**

1. Purpose begets vision
2. Vision begets goals
3. Purpose: The reason for which something is done or created or for which something exists. Your purpose is the reason for your being.
4. Vision: An act or power of anticipating which will or may come to be – giving direction for the outcome of goals and purpose
5. Goals: specific, desired outcomes that guide actions and effort towards a particular predetermined end

- **Purpose-driven lives: Gandhi's nonviolence, Mandela's fight for justice, Mother Teresa's compassion.**

Gandhi, Mandela and Mother Teresa are shining examples of lives well lived with purpose. Gandhi left his law practice behind and focused on liberating Asia and Africa from the yokes of colonial rule. He often took expeditions to South Africa to fellowship with the who were engaged in freedom struggle.

His crown jewel of endeavor came in the form of relentless non-violent resistance against British rule of his nation, India. He summed it all in the following thought.

“The main purpose of life is to live rightly, think rightly, act rightly. The soul must languish when we give all our thought to the body.” Mahatma Gandhi

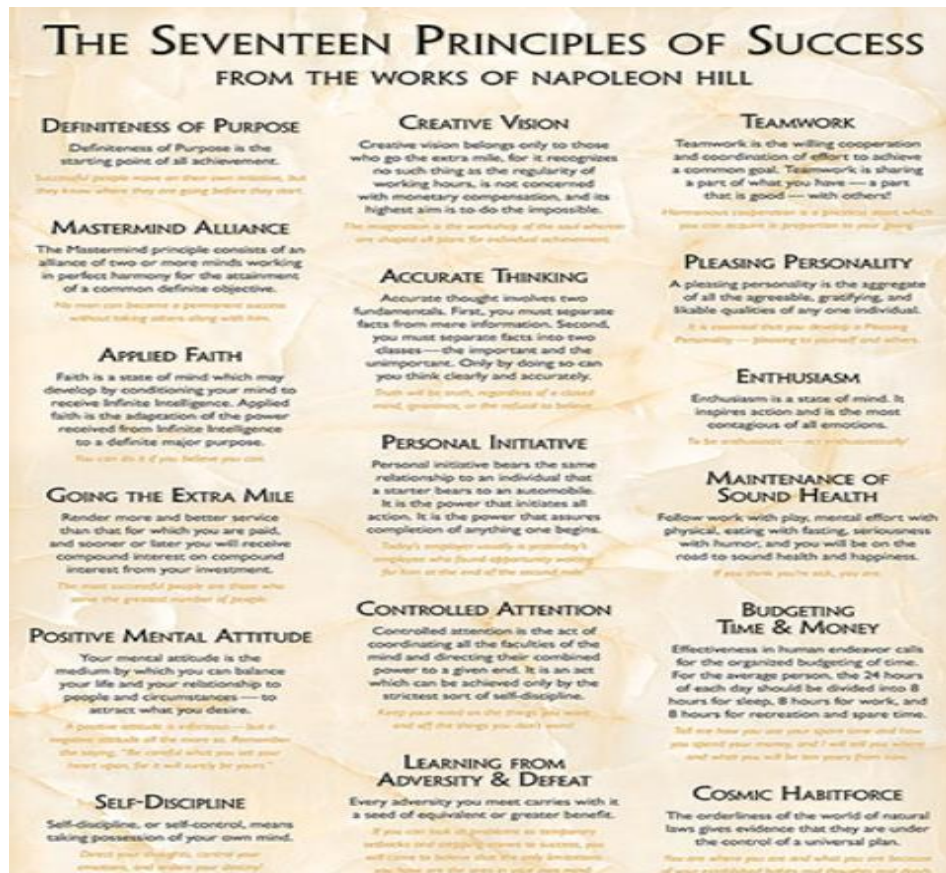
Mandela's purposeful fight for the liberation of his nation landed him in much trouble, and he was imprisoned and even labelled a terrorist among other things. It was his purpose that fueled his staying power. And he stayed the course until he birthed a rainbow nation out of Apartheid.

“For to be free is not merely to cast off one's chains, but to live in a way that respects and enhances the freedom of others.” – Nelson Mandela

Mother Teresa's life in Calcutta and beyond touched the world in a manner most special. Her compassion lingers on years after her demise. She did not only contribute to the assuaging of pain, but she also took part in it due to a purpose greater than herself.

“Help the poor while living among them, sharing their experience and treating them with kindness, compassion and empathy, but never pity.” – Mother Teresa

Napoleon Hill's 17 Success Principles Lists **Definiteness of Purpose** as the top attribute in ensuring achievement.



- **Activity:** Reflective journaling—“When did I feel most alive and fulfilled?” journalize on your personal experiences that felt, and those that feel, most meaningful.

Session 2 – The Foundations of Purpose (1.5 hours)

Objective: Explore foundational principles for finding purpose.

The Story of the Baobab Tree: According to <https://www.oneearth.org/species-of-the-week-african-baobab-tree/> The baobab tree is a legendary plant with folktales to boot. It is known as the “tree of life” because it sustains communities through fruit, shelter, and water storage.

In an arid climate, baobabs symbolize life in a landscape where little else can thrive. Its large whitish flowers open at night and fall within 24 hours, creating a beautiful display at both ends of the cycle.

Here is an excerpt from One Earth:

As a succulent, the tree absorbs and stores water from the rainy season in its massive trunk, producing a nutrient-dense fruit in the dry season, which can grow up to a foot long. The fruit contains tartaric acid and Vitamin C, serving as a vital nutrient and food source for many species.

They are also an essential source of water and shelter for hundreds of animals, including birds, lizards, monkeys, and even elephants – which can eat their bark for moisture when there is no water nearby. Bats pollinate the flowers, feeding on their nectar.

If a mere plant is created for specific value and purpose. How much more is your purpose and how much life can you sustain and support. This story edifies us that the true purpose of our life is to serve others.

There are many lessons to be learned here, some of which are

1. You have a major purpose
2. You have minor purposes
3. Your minor purposes must feed into your major purpose, not out of it.
4. You discover your purpose and you discover your true life’s meaning.



- **Key Topics:**

Napoleon Hill's *Definiteness of Purpose*.

Definiteness of Purpose – Your True Starting Point

{Intro Video Script

- ***Get clear*** – Know exactly what you want. No vague wishes—paint the picture.
- ***Get hungry*** – Want it so badly it pulls you out of bed in the morning.
- ***Get moving*** – Build your plan and take daily action—no excuses.
- ***Stay locked in*** – Focus your mind so opportunities and resources find you.

Why? Because a clear purpose gives you direction, draws the right people to you, and fuels your persistence when life gets tough.

When you have it, you don't just live life—you design it}

Napoleon Hill, one of the greatest voices in personal development, said it clearly: “Definiteness of purpose is the starting point of all achievement.” If you want to achieve anything worthwhile, this is where it begins.

Let us break it down, The Success Afrika-style:

1) Know exactly what you want

Don’t just say, “I want success” or “I want more money.” Those are vague wishes. Get crystal clear. Paint a vivid picture in your mind of what you want, what it looks like, feels like, and means for your life.

2) Develop a burning desire for it

A definite purpose is not a casual wish you think about when it’s convenient. It’s that deep, unshakable desire that keeps you awake at night and gets you out of bed in the morning ready to move.

3) Create your game plan

Once you know your target and you feel that burning desire, lay out your plan. Step by step. And keep it flexible—because life will test you, and you will need to adapt without losing sight of your goal.

4) Take consistent daily action

Your definite purpose should show up in your daily calendar. Every day you do something, big or small, that moves you closer to your goal. And you do not stop until it is done.

5) Focus your mind

When your mind is locked onto your purpose, something powerful happens: your subconscious starts working for you. You notice opportunities, people, and resources that you might have overlooked before.

Why does this matter a great deal?

- 1) It gives you direction – Your purpose becomes your North Star. You always know if you’re on course or drifting.
- 2) It attracts resources – People, ideas, and opportunities seem to “find” you because your focus is magnetic.
- 3) It builds persistence – When the journey gets tough, your purpose gives you the grit to keep going until you win.

When you develop definiteness of purpose, you will no longer just live, you will move with intention. That is the difference between drifting through life and creating a life worth living.

Zig Ziglar's *Wheel of Life*.

The Wheel of Life – Your Balance Check

Zig Ziglar, one of the greatest motivators of our time, taught that life is like a wheel. If one part of the wheel is flat, your ride through life will be bumpy—no matter how fast you try to go.

I like to think of it as your Life's Balance Scorecard. There are seven key spokes in this wheel:

1. Career – Your Work & Calling

Are you doing work that excites you, challenges you, and adds value to others? Your career isn't just a paycheck—it's part of your purpose.

2. Financial – Your Money & Resources

Money isn't everything, but it touches everything. Are you earning, saving, investing, and giving in ways that support your goals and values?

3. Spiritual – Your Faith & Inner Compass

This is your core—what guides you when life gets messy. Whether through faith, meditation, or reflection, are you staying connected to your deeper “why”?

4. Physical – Your Health & Energy

Your body is the vehicle that drives you through life. Are you giving it the fuel, rest, and movement it needs to perform at its best?

5. Intellectual – Your Growth & Learning

If you are not growing, you are dying. Are you reading, studying, and stretching your mind so you can keep adding value to the world?

6. Family – Your Relationships at Home

These are the people who know the real you. Are you investing time, love, and presence into your family relationships?

7. Social – Your Friends & Community

No one wins alone. Are you building healthy friendships, networks, and connections that inspire you and keep you accountable?

Know this:

If any one of the spokes is weak, the whole wheel wobbles. If several are weak, your journey slows—or stops. Balance does not mean every area is perfect all the time, but it does mean you are aware and working on them consistently.

When your Wheel of Life is round and strong, you do not only survive, but you roll smoothly toward your goals – You thrive!

Habits for a Meaningful Life – Og Mandino

Og Mandino, one of the most inspiring authors ever, taught that a meaningful life is not built overnight, it is shaped by the habits you practice every single day.

Here's how I break down his wisdom for you:

1. Start Each Day with Gratitude

Before you rush into your to-do list, pause. Name the blessings in your life—big or small. Gratitude sharpens your perspective and keeps you grounded.

2. Greet Each Day with Love in Your Heart

People are your greatest resource. Approach everyone—family, colleagues, even strangers—with kindness and respect. Love opens doors that force cannot.

3. Persist Until You Succeed

Challenges are not stop signs; they are detours. Keep showing up. Every failure carries a lesson, and every lesson moves you closer to your win.

4. Live Each Day as if It is Your Last

Do not postpone joy, impact, or purpose. Do the thing today—make the call, take the walk, say “I love you.” Life is too short for “someday.”

5. Master Your Emotions

You cannot always control what happens, but you can control your response. Stay steady when others panic and stay humble when you win.

6. Multiply Your Value Every Day

Get a little better daily—learn a skill, solve a problem, or serve someone in a new way. Growth is the fuel of a meaningful life.

7. Take Action Now: Tomorrow is not promised.

Do not wait for perfect conditions. You will never have all the answers before you start. Move, and clarity will meet you along the way.

The Big Picture:

Og Mandino believed—and I agree—that meaningful living is not about chasing things; it is about becoming more. Practice these habits daily, and life will not just happen to you—you will be the one shaping it.

- **Activity:** Use Zig Ziglar’s Wheel of Life to rate and reflect on different life domains.
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Session 3 – Purpose and Service (1 hour)

Objective: See how purpose is linked to serving others.

The Proverb: “When You Take the Elevator Up, Send It Back Down for Others.”

This simple proverb carries a powerful life lesson:

When you succeed—when you reach higher levels in life—it is not just about you. It is also about helping others climb.

Let’s break it down.

1. The Elevator Up – Your Success Journey

The “elevator” is whatever took you to the next level—your skills, your opportunities, your mentors, your hard work. You have moved up in life, whether in career, finances, influence, or personal growth.

2. Sending It Back Down – Creating Pathways for Others

Once you are on a higher floor, do not just enjoy the view alone. Make it easier for others to rise—through mentoring, sharing knowledge, creating opportunities, or opening doors they could not open on their own.

3. Why This Matters

Because someone did it for you – Even if you worked hard, you also benefited from someone else’s guidance, time, or belief in you.

Because success is sweeter when shared – True leadership is not measured by how far you go, but by how many you take with you.

Because it multiplies impact – When you help one person rise, they can help others in return.

My Take:

Success without significance is empty. If your climb only benefits you, it is a small victory. But when you “send the elevator back down,” you turn your success into a legacy. That is how you create an impact that outlives you. I am not a mentor until I create other mentors.

Wangari Maathai planted trees not for herself but for future generations.

- **Key Topics:**

Lessons from Mother Teresa – Small Acts, Big Love

Mother Teresa was not famous because she held a position of power or held major bank accounts. She is remembered because she lived a life of deep compassion—proving that even the smallest acts, when done with love, can transform lives and change the world.

Here is how we can bring her wisdom into our own daily lives:

1. Start Where You Are

You do not need to wait for the “right time” or have a perfect plan. Mother Teresa said, “Never worry about numbers. Help one person at a time and always start with the person nearest you.”

2. See People, Not Problems

She did not just see poverty, she saw people. She looked into their eyes, called them by name, and treated them with dignity. In your world, slow down enough to truly notice people.

3. Love Through Action

Love is not just a feeling—it is a verb. A kind word, a listening ear, a meal shared, a hand extended. Do not underestimate the power of these moments.

4. Do Small Things Well

Mother Teresa believed that greatness is found in the quality of small acts. Fold the blanket neatly. Write the note thoughtfully. Show up on time. Excellence in small things builds trust and influence.

5. Keep Your Heart Soft

The world can harden you if you let it. She chose compassion over cynicism, even in the toughest environments. Guard your heart so you can keep giving without bitterness.

My Take:

Big impact does not require big titles or big money. It starts with doing small things with great love—and doing them consistently. That is how you create ripples that reach farther than you will ever see.

Lessons from Nelson Mandela – Unity and Justice

Nelson Mandela's life teaches us that real leadership is not about power over people, it is about bringing people together and standing for what is right, even when it costs you everything.

Here is how we can live out his example:

1. Choose Unity Over Division

Mandela understood that a divided nation cannot thrive. He worked to unite people across race, class, and politics. In your life, ask yourself: Am I building bridges or walls?

2. Stand Firm for Justice

He spent 27 years in prison because he refused to compromise on equality. Justice sometimes demands patience, endurance, and the courage to speak truth to power—even when it is unpopular.

3. Forgive, But Do not Forget the Lesson

Mandela forgave his oppressors, not to erase the past, but to create a future. Forgiveness is not weakness—it is the strength to release bitterness so progress can begin.

4. Lead With Example, Not Just Words

He did not just preach unity, but he embodied it. His humility, discipline, and servant leadership made people follow him willingly. Your actions will always speak louder than your speeches.

5. See the Bigger Picture

Mandela thought beyond his own comfort and lifetime. He worked for the freedom and dignity of generations yet unborn. That is the mindset of a true leader, and it brings boundless rewards.

Thought to Carry Forward:

Unity and justice are not lofty ideals for history books—they are daily choices. Whether in your family, workplace, or community, you can be the one who refuses to divide, stands for what is right, and leads with integrity. When you do this, the rewards in peace of mind and material riches will always follow you.

- Humility and selflessness as a foundation of service.

Humility & Selflessness – The True Foundation of Service

Real service is not about recognition or applause, it is about meeting needs, lifting others, and making a difference without demanding the spotlight. Humility and selflessness are the bedrock of that kind of service.

1. Put the Mission Above Your Ego

When your goal is to serve, it is not about who gets the credit; it is about whether the need gets met. Focus on the mission, not on your image.

2. Listen More Than You Speak

Humility starts with listening. You cannot truly serve people if you do not understand their needs. Listen with an open mind, without rushing to give answers.

3. Share the Stage

Selflessness means creating space for others to shine. Give people credit for their contributions, celebrate their wins, and never be afraid to lift someone higher than yourself.

4. Serve Without Expecting Return

Service is most powerful when it is unconditional. Do not keep the score or wait for favors in return. The reward is in knowing you made an impact.

5. Stay Grounded, No Matter How High You Rise

Titles, positions, or wealth should never make you forget your roots. Stay approachable, relatable, and connected to the people you serve.

Major Take:

Humility keeps you grounded. Selflessness keeps you focused on others. Together, they make the service pure, powerful, and transformational. When you serve this way, you do not just help people—you inspire them to serve too.

- **Reflection:** Personal Introspection: “Who are you serving today and how?”
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Session 4 – Overcoming Obstacles to Purpose (1 hour)

Objective: Learn how to push through internal and external challenges.

- **Folktale:** *The Tortoise and the Heavy Load* – A tortoise carried a load for days because he believed each step took him closer to home. (Lesson: Steady progress despite obstacles.)
 - **Key Topics:**
 - Napoleon Hill on fear vs. faith.
 - Gandhi’s courage in the face of opposition.
 - Building inner clarity.
 - **Activity:** Visualization—Picture yourself breaking through a major barrier.
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WEEK 2 – Living, Sharing, and Sustaining Your Purpose

Session 5 – Practical Tools for Defining Your Purpose (1.5 hours)

Objective: Craft a personal purpose statement.

- **Anecdote:** *The Fisherman and the Merchant* – A fisherman content with his simple life helps a wealthy merchant understand that true purpose isn’t about riches but fulfillment.
 - **Key Topics:**
 - Success Afrika techniques.
 - Identifying passions & strengths.
 - Aligning purpose with values.
 - **Activity:** Write a first draft of your purpose statement; get peer feedback.
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Session 6 – Purpose in Action (1.5 hours)

Objective: Integrate purpose into everyday life.

- **Proverb:** “*The child who is not embraced by the village will burn it down to feel its warmth.*” (Lesson: Purpose thrives in connection and contribution.)
 - **Key Topics:**
 - Og Mandino on purposeful habits.
 - Time management for meaningful living (Success Magazine insights).
 - African leaders & entrepreneurs acting on purpose.
 - **Activity:** Create a weekly schedule aligned with your purpose.
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Session 7 – Sharing and Sustaining Your Purpose (1.5 hours)

Objective: Learn how to inspire others.

- **Anecdote:** *The Story of the Clay Lamp* – A small lamp lit many others without losing its flame. (Lesson: Sharing your light strengthens it.)
 - **Key Topics:**
 - Zig Ziglar’s “help others get what they want” principle.
 - Gandhi’s enduring influence.
 - Ongoing growth via Success Afrika and other resources.
 - **Activity:** Design a small community project that reflects your purpose.
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Session 8 – Reflection and Forward Planning (1 hour)

Objective: Consolidate learning and set a clear future path.

- **Allegory:** *The River and the Stone* – Over time, water shapes the hardest rock (Lesson: Purpose shapes life through steady persistence).
 - **Key Topics:**
 - Review purpose statements.
 - Strategies for resilience.
 - Inspiring others through example.
 - **Activity:** Present purpose statements & one-year action plans.
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Learning Resources

- **Videos:** Success Afrika YouTube Channel (African perspective motivation).
- **Articles & Tools:** Success.com on purpose and productivity.
- **Books:**
 - *Think and Grow Rich* – Napoleon Hill.

- *The Greatest Salesman in the World* – Og Mandino.
 - *See You at the Top* – Zig Ziglar.
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Expected Outcomes

- Deep cultural and personal connection to life's purpose.
- A written, actionable purpose statement.
- Ability to align daily living with purpose.
- Skills to inspire and mentor others in finding their purpose.